

Working in Korea & Visa Plan

For International Students (English)

Part-time work (D-2/D-4) · Post-graduation employment (D-10/E-7) · Long-term stay (K-STAR/F-2/F-5)

2026.9 · Based on MOJ HiKorea manual / Camnemi offline consulting only

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1. Visa Roadmap

Typical path: **D-4 Language** → **D-2 Degree** → **D-10 Job-seeking / E-7 Work** → **F-2·F-5·K-STAR (PR)**

Step	Visa	Purpose	Key condition
1	D-4 General Training	Korean/foreign language (D-4-1 / D-4-7)	HS grad+, university-affiliated language center
2	D-2 Student	Degree (jr-college/BA/MA/PhD/research/exchange/work-study/visiting)	TOPIK 2+ / IELTS · financial proof
3	D-10 Job-seeking	After graduation (max 2 yrs)	Degree, active job search
4	E-7 Specific Activity	Professional employment	Graduation + job offer, or D-10→E-7
5	F-2 Resident	Points-based	Income-Korean-age points
6	F-5 PR	Permanent residence	Long-stay requirements
★	K-STAR F-2-7S	STEM grad → PR in 3 yrs, job-free	32 designated univs, master's/PhD

D-4→D-2: apply in Korea for status change after entering; prior language-study attendance/grade cert required.

2. Part-Time Work (D-2/D-4)

Limited to ordinary student part-time activity (simple labor). Private tutoring strictly restricted. Need Korean ability + university advisor confirmation.

Allowed hours (weekday)

Level	Korean req	Weekday (met)	Holidays/vacation	Accredited univ
Junior college	TOPIK 3 / KIIP stage 3 (61pts) / Sejong mid-1	25h	Unlimited	30h
Bachelor's 1-2 yr	-	25h	Unlimited	30h
Bachelor's 3-4 yr	TOPIK 4 / KIIP stage 4 (81pts) / Sejong mid-2	25h	Unlimited	30h
Master's/PhD	-	30h	Unlimited	35h

When allowed? D-2-1~4/6/7: immediately (D-2-8 visiting: after 6 months). D-4-1/7: after 6 months.

Duration/places: D-2 = max 1 yr, 2 places / D-4 = max 6 months, 1 place.

Penalty for unpermitted work: 1st = warning & stay granted (construction-sector illegal work = departure, no exception), 2nd = forced deportation. Condition violation: 1st warning / 2nd no part-time during study / 3rd student status revoked.

3. Employment After Graduation

From	To	Condition
D-2	E-7 (professional)	Graduate + job offer confirmed → change immediately
D-2	D-10 (job-seeking)	Not yet employed after grad (max 2 yrs)
D-2	F-2-7 (points)	Meet points criteria
D-2	F-5 (PR)	Long-stay criteria
D-4-6 (20mo training)	E-7	Overseas jr-college+, domestic training completed, national cert + KIIP stage 4
E-9	E-7-4 (skilled)	5 yrs legal work (4 yrs + KIIP stage 3 counts)
E-9	F-2 / F-5	Long-stay criteria

E-7 eligible occupations: 94 total — professional (E-7-1) 67, semi-professional (E-7-2) 10, general skilled (E-7-3).

E-7-4 skilled worker: root/manufacturing/construction skilled (S700/S740), agriculture (S610). 2026 wage threshold: KRW 26M+/yr.

4. Long-Term Stay & PR

Visa	What	Benefit
K-STAR (F-2-7S)	STEM master's/PhD from 32 designated univs	Stay 5 yrs job-free; F-5 PR in 3 yrs; special naturalization
F-2 Resident	Points system	Income-Korean-age points
F-5 PR	Long-term stay	5+ yrs, income & Korean
KIIP	Social Integration Program	Replaces TOPIK + points for PR/naturalization

5. Key Notes

- Part-time-work special rule: incidental gratuities, prize money, or payment for activities that do not infringe the essence of student status are exempt from the permit requirement.
- Paid research (D-2): research/internship tied to study within your own university = exempt from part-time-work permit. Research unrelated to study = permit needed. Off-campus study-linked research/internship = permit needed; off-campus unrelated research = status-outside-activity permit (E-3).
- Field-work semester: standard field-work semester programs and mandatory practicum curricula are exempt from the part-time-work permit; voluntary field work needs the permit.
- D-2 stay-extension special caps: jr-college max 3 yrs (3-yr program: 4), bachelor's max 6 yrs (5-yr: 7), master's max 5 yrs (3-yr: 6), PhD max 8 yrs (2-yr: 7) from enrollment.
- Re-entry permit exemption: a registered international student re-entering within 1 year of departure is exempt; re-entry between 1-2 years may apply for a multiple re-entry permit.
- E-7 special for excellent-private-institution trainees: completing D-4-6 (20+ months), obtaining a national certificate, and completing KIIP stage 4+ allows E-7 status change in the trained field (except E-7-4).

6. Financial Proof (2026)

Type	Capital region	Non-capital
D-2 (degree)	KRW 20M (~\$14,300)	KRW 16M (~\$11,500)
D-4 (language)	KRW 10M (~\$7,200)	KRW 8M (~\$5,800)
Note	School/region vary; some require ≥28-day deposit	

2026 visa-intensive-screening universities (20) are excluded from recommendations. Cambodia = 'other country' → some D-4 require 4 semesters; deadlines may be less favorable.